

In the reading for today, Sider's aim is to present a paradox involving a series of claims which, from the point of view of standard views about judgement and the afterlife, seem quite plausible. Let's work through his reasoning.

1. **Non-universality**: some people go to heaven, and some to hell.
 2. **Divine control**: it is up to God who goes to heaven and who goes to hell.
 3. God sends some people (group A) to heaven and some people (group B) to hell. (1,2)
 4. **Badness**: people in hell are very, very much worse off than people in heaven.
 5. God makes group A much better off than group B. (3,4)
 6. **Proportionality**: justice prohibits very unequal treatment of persons who are very similar in relevant respects.
 7. **Justice**: God's judgement about who goes to heaven & hell is just.
 8. No one in group A is very similar in relevant respects to anyone in group B. (5,6,7)
 9. **Dichotomy**: there are exactly two states in the afterlife, heaven and hell.
-

C. There is some way of dividing all humans into two groups so that no member of one is very similar in relevant respects to any member of the other. (8,9)

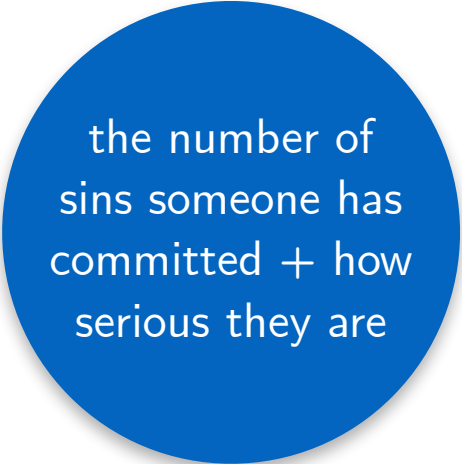
The problem, Sider thinks, is that there is no way of dividing up the population of people which avoids putting relevantly very similar people into different groups.

The most straightforward way to reply to the argument is to say that the conclusion of the argument is true. Then the question is: what are the relevant respects? What are the properties that God looks at to determine who goes to heaven and who to hell?

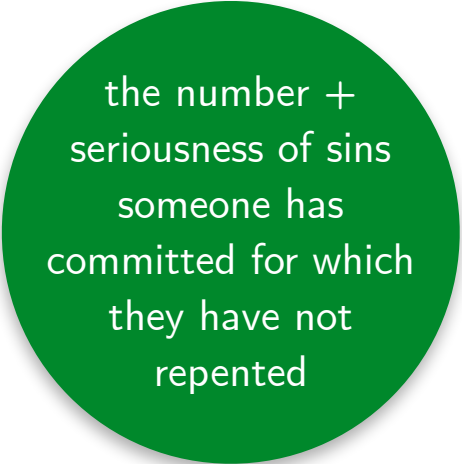
What could these properties be? Let's consider some possibilities.

A large, solid orange circle serves as the background for the text.

the number of
sins someone has
committed

A solid blue circle with a slight drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the number of sins someone has committed + how serious they are" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in five lines.

the number of
sins someone has
committed + how
serious they are

A large green circle with a white drop shadow is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, white text is arranged in six lines, centered horizontally.

the number +
seriousness of sins
someone has
committed for which
they have not
repented



the person's faith
and trust in God

Let's consider a different possibility. What if, when God encounters a borderline case of the relevant properties (whatever they are) God does not send the person to heaven or hell, and instead gives the person more time to determine whether they deserve to go to heaven or hell.

In the Catholic tradition, this is close to the idea that some people after death go to
neither heaven nor hell but rather to purgatory.

On the standard Catholic view, any who goes to purgatory eventually goes to heaven.

But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to purgatory, God is deciding who eventually goes to heaven and who eventually goes to hell — which means that again we need some way of dividing the “borderline cases” from those who go to hell, and the problem is unsolved.

Could a different view of purgatory, on which some people in purgatory eventually go to hell, help?

It seems that he does. He is paying people very different hourly wages despite the fact that their relevant properties (the kind of work they were doing) was very similar.

The landowner seeks to argue that he is not as follows.

Does the Landowner violate Proportionality?

“The kingdom of heaven is like a landowner who went out early in the morning to hire men to work in his vineyard. He agreed to pay them a denarius for the day. About the third hour he went out and found some people in the marketplace doing nothing. He told them, “You also go and work in my vineyard and I will pay you what is right.” So they went. He went out again in the sixth hour and the ninth hour and did the same thing.

About the eleventh hour he went out and found still others standing around doing nothing. He asked them, “Why have you been standing around all day doing nothing?” “No one has hired us,” they replied. He said to them, “You also go and work in my vineyard.”

When evening came, the owner of the vineyard asked his foreman to call in the workers and pay them their wages, starting with the ones who were hired last. The workers who were hired about the eleventh hour each received a denarius. So those who were hired first expected to receive more. But each one of them also received a denarius.

When they received it, they began to grumble against the landowner, “These men who were hired last have worked only one hour, and you have made them equal to us who have worked in the heat all day.”

The landowner said, “Friend, I am not being unfair to you. Didn’t you agree to work for a denarius? Take your pay and go. I want to pay the people who were hired last the same as I paid you. Don’t I have the right to do what I want with my own money? Or are you envious because I am generous?”

Is the landowner unjust?

Here's a different case to test your thoughts about the parable and its application to the afterlife.

Can one defend the generous professor in the same way we defended the landowner? It might seem so. But many have the thought that the generous professor acts unjustly.

The generous professor

The instructor of an introductory philosophy class gives out very clear standards by which assignments will be graded, and a very clear grading scheme for the class. At the end of the class, some students have A's, some A-'s, some B+'s, and so on down to a few D's and F's. The professor decides to be generous to the students with a B+ or higher, and gives them all an A; he leaves the other grades unchanged.

If you are tempted to think that the landowner acts justly but that the generous professor does not, the question to ask yourself is: Why are these cases different? What explains why one is just and the other unjust?



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox

A solid red circle with a soft drop shadow, containing white text.

evil & lives
not worth
living

quite plausible. Let's work through this reasoning.

In the reading for today, Sider's aim is to present a paradox involving a series of claims

which, from the point of standard views about judgment and the afterlife, seem



5. God makes group A much better off than group B. (3,4)

~Justice: God's judgement about who goes to heaven & hell is just.

to be ill. (I, as)

2 **Divine control:** it is up to God who gives to heaven and who goes to hell.

member one is very similar in relevant respects to any member the

3. God sends some people (group A) to heaven and some people (group B)

9 **Dichotomy:** there are exactly two states in the afterlife, heaven and hell.

8 Mon group A is very similar in relevant respects to any other group

There is one way of dividing all humans into two groups that

1. **Non-universality:** some people go to heaven, and some to hell.

which are very similar in relevant respects.



deserve in.

B. (B, O, R)

otthier. (8,9)

6 **Proportionality**: justice prohibits every unequal treatment of persons

4. **Badness:** people in hell are very, very much worse off than people in

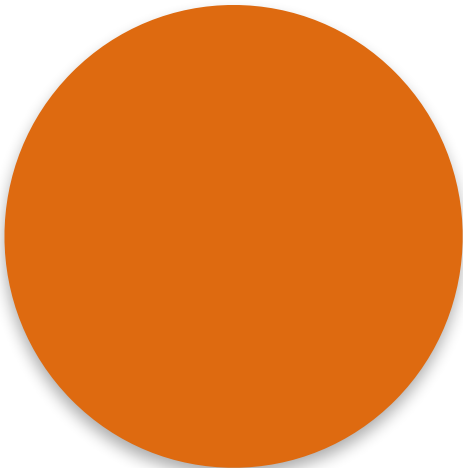
people who are putting relevantly similar people into different groups.

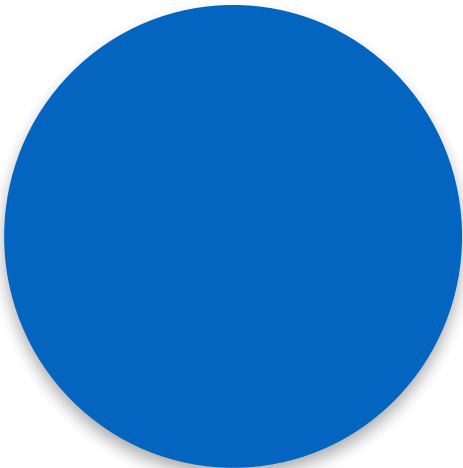
The problem, Sider thinks, is that there is no way of dividing up the population of

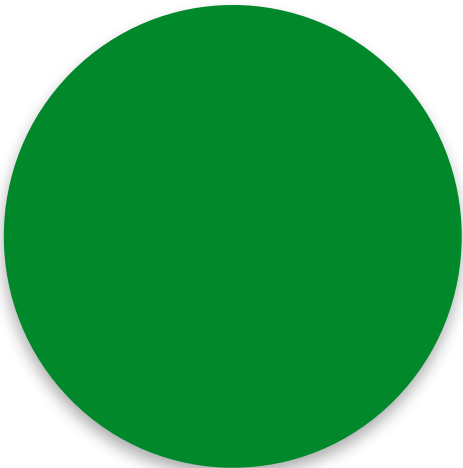
The most straightforward way to reply to the argument is to say that the conclusion of

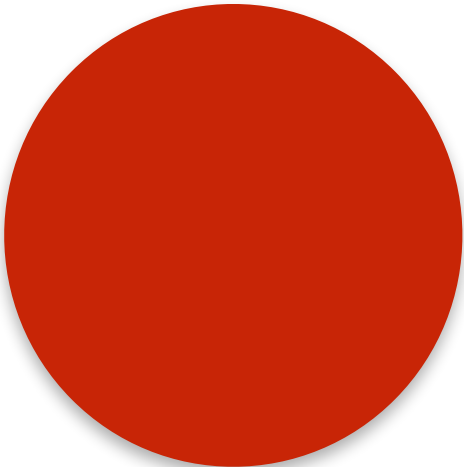
the argument is true. Then the question is: what are the relevant respects? What are the

properties that God looks at to determine who goes to heaven and who to hell?









hell, and instead gives the person more time to determine whether they deserve to go

to heaven or hell.

the relevant properties (whatever they are) God does not send the person to heaven or

Let's consider a different possibility. What if, when God creates a border line

In the Catholic tradition, this is close to the idea that some people after death go to

neither heaven nor hell but rather to purgatory.

that again we need some way of dividing the 'borderline cases' from those who go to

hell, and the problem is unsolved.

deciding whether eventually goes to hell — which means

On the standard Catholic view, anyone who goes to purgatory eventually goes to heaven.

But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to purgatory, God is

Could a different view of purgatory, on which some people in purgatory eventually go to

help, help?

It seems that he does. He is paying people very different hourly wages

despite the fact that their relevant properties (the kind of work they

were doing) was very similar.

application to the afterlife.

Here's a different case to test your thoughts about the parabola and its

answer? It might seem so. But many have thought that the

Can one defend the genus professor in the same way we defend the

generous professor acts unjustly.



out very clear standards by which assignments will be

graded, and a very clear grading scheme for the class. At

The instructor of an introductory philosophy class gives

some B_i 's, and so on down to a few D 's and E 's. The

The generalis professor

the end of the class, some students have A's, some A-'s,

professor decides to be generous to the students with a

other grades unchanged.

B or higher, and gives them all an A ; he leaves the

If you are tempted to think that the landowners act justly but that the

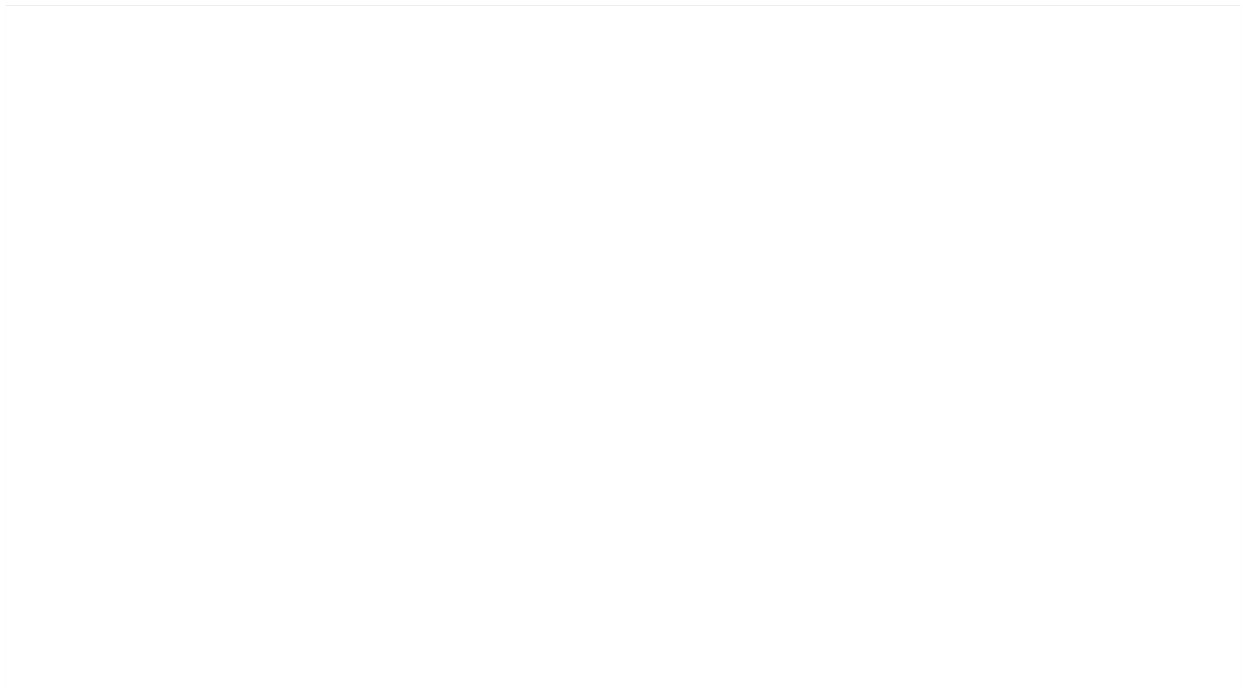
unjust?

gender professor does not, the question to ask yourself is: Why are

these are different? What explains why one is just and the other

The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:



the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

into external punishment, but the rights into

eternis in die !!

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

many of the major monotheistic religions practiced with the existence of a

perfectly good Good?



this glory, and all the angels with him . . .

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

and the wild sheep are then from another

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

they will go away into eternal punishment,

but the rights are all in it.

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?











evil & lives
not worth
living

Let's try to layout Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the

the existence of a perfectly good God.

traditional doctrine of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

open for what those properties might be; just have a name for them,

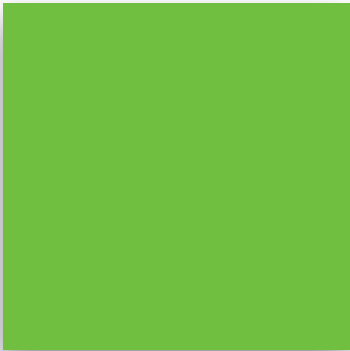
It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to

Let's call them the relevant properties.

heaven and hell based on certain properties of these people. We will have



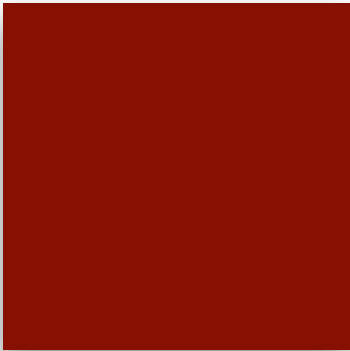










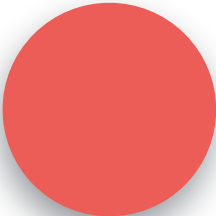


It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.

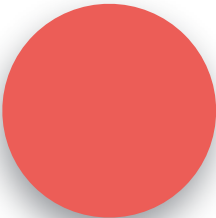


replies to the
paradox





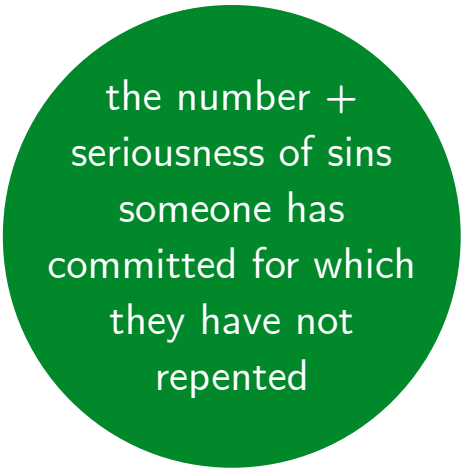
the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



A large, solid orange circle serves as the background for the text.

the number of
sins someone has
committed

the number of
sins someone has
committed + how
serious they are



the number +
seriousness of sins
someone has
committed for which
they have not
repented



the person's faith
and trust in God